Steering Committee
Request for Comments November 2024

BGIN Group Guidelines and Procedures

Status of this Memo

This memo provides information for the BGIN community. It does not specify a blockchain governance standard of any kind. Distribution of this memo is unlimited.

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Abstract

This document describes the guidelines and procedures for formation and operation of BGIN working groups (WGs) and study groups (SGs), which supplements the Process Document. It also describes the formal relationship between BGIN Groups and the BGIN Steering Committee (SC) and the basic duties of BGIN participants, including Group Chair(s) (described as "Coordinator(s)" in the Process Document), and participants (described as "Contributor(s)" in the Process Document).

1. Introduction

The Blockchain Governance Initiative Network (BGIN) is a large, open community of engineers, business operators, academic researchers, regulators concerned with blockchain technology. The primary activities of the BGIN are performed by committees known as groups. Groups tend to have a narrow focus and a lifetime bounded by the completion of a specific set of tasks, although there are exceptions.

There is no formal membership in the BGIN. Participation is open to all unless otherwise specified. This participation may be by online contribution, attendance at face-to-face meetings and conferences, or both. Anyone from the blockchain community who has the time and interest is urged to participate in BGIN meetings and any of its online group discussions. Participation is by individual contributors, rather than by formal representatives of organizations.

This document defines procedures and guidelines for the formulation and operation of groups in the BGIN. It defines the relations of groups to other bodies within the BGIN. The duties of group Chairs and responsible SC Members with respect to the operation of the groups are also defined.

2. Group Formation

BGIN groups are the primary mechanism for development of BGIN specifications and guidelines, many of which are intended to be standards or recommendations. A group may be established at the initiative of a SC Member or it may be initiated by an individual or group of individuals. Anyone interested in creating a BGIN group shall obtain the advice and consent of the BGIN SC and proceed through the formal steps detailed in this section.

Groups are typically created to address a specific problem or to produce one or more specific deliverables (a guideline, standards specification, etc.). Groups are generally expected to be short-lived in nature. Upon completion of its goals and achievements of its objectives, the group is terminated. A group may also be terminated for other reasons (see section 4).

Alternatively, with the concurrence of the BGIN SC, the responsible SC Member, the Group Chair(s), and the participants, the objectives or assignment of the group may be extended by modifying the group's charter through a rechartering process (see section 5).

2.1. Criteria for formation

When determining whether it is appropriate to create a group, the responsible SC Member and the BGIN SC will consider several issues:

- Are the issues that the group plans to address clear and relevant to the blockchain community?
- Are the goals specific and reasonably achievable, and achievable within a reasonable time frame?
- What are the risks and urgency of the work, to determine the level of effort required?
- Do the group's activities overlap with those of another group? If so, it may still be appropriate with those of another group? If so, it may still be appropriate to create the working group, but this question must be considered carefully by the BGIN SC as subdividing efforts often dilutes the available expertise.
- Is there sufficient interest within the BGIN in the group's topic with enough people willing to expend the effort to produce the desired result? Groups require considerable effort, including management of the group process, editing of group documents, and contributing to the document text. Those roles typically cannot all be handled by one person; a minimum of four or five active participants in the management positions are typically required in addition to a minimum of one dozen people that will occasionally attend the group meetings and contribute on the mailing list.
- Is there enough expertise within the BGIN in the group's topic, and are those people interested in contributing to the group?
- Is there a foundation of end-users and stakeholders who are likely to be interested in the planned work?
- Does BGIN play a reasonable role in the determination of the standards or recommendations? While there are many topics that are of interest to BGIN members, in some cases, BGIN's standards or recommendations may not have the capacity to influence the direction of the "real world." For example, this may occur when other standardization bodies are already fulfilling the same role.
- Are all known intellectual property rights relevant to the proposed group's efforts understood?
- Is the proposed work plan an open BGIN effort or is it an attempt to "bless" non-BGIN technology where the effect of input from BGIN participants may be limited?

Considering the above criteria, the BGIN SC Members, using his or her best judgement, will decide whether to pursue the formation of the group through the chartering process.

2.2. Charter

The formation of a group requires a charter which is primarily negotiated between a prospective group Chair(s) and the responsible SC Member(s), although final approval is made by the

BGIN SC. A charter is a contract between a group and the BGIN to perform a set of tasks. A charter:

1) Lists relevant administrative information for the working group;
2) Specifies the direction or objectives of the working group and describes the approach that will be taken to achieve the goals; and
3) Enumerates a set of milestones together with time frames for their completion.

When the prospective Chair(s), the responsible SC Member and the BGIN Secretary General are satisfied with the charter form and content, it becomes the basis for forming a group.

Charters may be renegotiated periodically to reflect the current status, organization or goals of the group (see section 5). Hence, a charter is a contract between the BGIN and the group which is committing to meet explicit milestones and delivering specific outcomes.

Specifically, each charter consists of the following sections:

1) a clear statement of purpose;
   The focus and intent of the group shall be set forth briefly. By reading this section alone, an individual should be able to decide whether this group is relevant to their own work. It must give a brief summary of the problem area, basis, goal(s) and approach(es) planned for the working group.

   To facilitate evaluation of the intended work and to provide on- going guidance to the working group, the charter must describe the problem being solved and should discuss objectives and expected impact with respect to:

   - Architecture
   - Operations
   - Network management
   - Scaling
   Transition (where applicable)

2) an initial Scope, which must be related to the purpose of the BGIN and which will include a definition of what is and is not the envisioned work or scope of the Group;
   The working group charter shall establish a timetable for specific work items. While this may be renegotiated over time, the list of milestones and dates facilitates the Responsible SC Member's tracking of group progress and status, and it is indispensable to potential participants identifying the critical moments for input.

3) a proposed list of contemplated Work Product, if a Group, including working titles, to be produced (and any other deliverables) and projected completion dates;
   Milestones shall consist of deliverables that can be qualified as showing specific achievement. It is helpful to specify milestones for every 3-6 months, so that progress can be gauged easily. This milestone list is expected to be updated periodically.

4) the language in which the Group will conduct business;
   The group shall use English unless otherwise specified.

5) the method of work including any virtual or planned face-to-face meetings, collaboration tools, etc.;

6) a basis for assessing whether the Group should be formed; any related work being done in other Groups or organizations, why the proposed new Group is necessary, and any proposed liaison with any such other Groups or organizations; and

7) the names, email addresses, and any Constituent affiliations of at least the Minimum Membership who support forming the Group ("Proposers") and the Group Chair(s) (the proposed "Coordinators").
A group name should be reasonably descriptive or identifiable. Additionally, the group shall define an acronym (maximum 8 printable ASCII characters) to reference the group in the BGIN directories, mailing lists, and general documents. The group may have one or more Chairs to perform the administrative functions of the group. The email address(es) of the Chair(s) shall be included. The Responsible SC Member who acts as the primary BGIN SC contact for the group.

2.3. Charter review & approval

Once the Responsible SC Member has approved the group charter, the charter is submitted for review and approval by the BGIN SC. After a review period of at least 15 days the proposed charter is posted to the BGIN website, Discourse channel, and the mailing list as a public notice that the formation of the group is being considered.

If the BGIN SC approves the formation of the group it remands the approved charter to the BGIN Secretary General who records and enters the information into the BGIN database.

3. Group Operation

Groups are autonomous and each determines most of the details of its own operation with respect to session participation, reaching closure, etc. The core rule for operation is that acceptance or agreement is achieved via group "rough consensus".

A number of procedural questions and issues will arise over time, and it is the function of the Group Chair(s) to manage the group process, keeping in mind that the overall purpose of the group is to make progress towards reaching rough consensus in realizing the working group's goals and objectives.

A set of guidelines and practices are listed here, with actual choices typically determined by the group participants and the Chair(s).

3.1. Session planning

For coordinated, structured group interactions, the Chair(s) must publish a draft agenda well in advance of the actual session. The agenda should contain at least:

- The items for discussion;
- The estimated time necessary per item; and
- A clear indication of what documents the participants will need to read before the session in order to be well prepared.

Publication of the working group agenda shall include sending a copy of the agenda to the working group mailing list and the relevant Discourse channel.

All working group actions shall be taken in a public forum, and wide participation is encouraged except otherwise specified. A working group will conduct much of its business via electronic mail distribution lists but may meet periodically to discuss and review task status and progress, to resolve specific issues and to direct future activities.

BGIN General Meetings (Block meetings) serve as the primary venue for in-person sessions of these groups, while more frequent Group Meetings are typically held online (though not mandatory). Interim meetings are subject to the same rules regarding advance notice, reporting, open participation, and procedures that apply to other group meetings.

If the organization of a Layer 2 Meetup is decided by the BGIN SC, each group may propose agenda items for in-person sessions. All group meetings (including those held outside of BGIN venues) must produce and report meeting minutes. The minutes should include the agenda of the meeting and a record of discussions, including any decisions made.

The chair is responsible for ensuring that session minutes are prepared and distributed, although the actual work may be delegated to a person designated by the chair. The minutes must be properly stored in the BGIN database.

3.2. Session venue

Each group will determine the balance of email and face-to- face sessions that is appropriate for achieving its milestones. Electronic mail permits the widest participation; face-to-face meetings often permit better focus and therefore can be more efficient for reaching a consensus among a core of the group participants. In determining the balance, the group must ensure that its process does not serve to exclude contribution by email-only participants. Decisions reached during a face-to-face meeting about topics or issues which have not been discussed on the mailing list, or are significantly different from previously arrived mailing list consensus must be reviewed on the mailing list.

BGIN General Meetings (Block Meetings)

If a group needs a session at a general meeting (Block meeting), the Group Chair must apply for time-slots as soon as the announcement of the general meeting is made to the Group Chairs. Group Chairs may want to coordinate sessions in their focus and request that time slots be coordinated through the responsible SC Member, BGIN Co-Chairs, and Secretary General.

A scheduling request MUST contain:

- The group name and full title;
- The amount of time requested;
- The rough outline of the agenda that is expected to be covered; and
- Related groups that should not be scheduled for the same time slot(s);

Layer2 Meetups

If a group needs a session at a Layer2 Meetup, the Group Chair must apply for time-slots as soon as the announcement of the meeting is made to the Group Chairs. WG-Chairs may want to coordinate sessions in their focus and request that time slots be coordinated through the responsible SC Member, BGIN Co-Chairs, and Secretary General.

A scheduling request MUST contain:

- The group name and full title;
- The amount of time requested;
- The rough outline of the agenda that is expected to be covered; and

- Related groups that should not be scheduled for the same time slot(s);

NOTE: While open discussion and contribution is essential to working group success, the Group Chair is responsible for ensuring forward progress. When acceptable to the Group, the Group Chair may call for restricted participation (but not restricted attendance!) at BGIN group sessions for the purpose of achieving progress. The Group Chair then has the authority to refuse to grant the floor to any individual who is unprepared or otherwise covering inappropriate material, or who, in the opinion of the Chair is disrupting the Group process. The Chair should consult with the Responsible SC Member(s) if the individual persists in disruptive behavior.

Group Meetings

Group Meetings can be scheduled at the discretion of the Group Chairs. It is not mandatory to hold meetings on a regular basis, and the balance between online and offline meetings should be determined with priority given to achieving the group's objectives.

Offline

It can be quite useful to conduct email exchanges and talk on Discourse in the same manner as a face-to-face session, with published schedule and agenda, as well as on-going summarization and consensus polling.

The choice of operational style is made by the group itself. It is important to note, however, that offline communication is possible for a much wider base of interested persons than is attendance at BGIN general meetings and Layer2 meetups, due to the time and expense required to attend.

As with face-to-face sessions occasionally one or more individuals may engage in behavior offline which disrupts the Group’s progress. In these cases the Group Chair should attempt to discourage the behavior by communicating directly with the offending individual rather than on the open place. If the behavior persists then the Group Chair must involve the responsible SC Member in the issue. As a last resort and after explicit warnings, the responsible SC Member, with the approval of the BGIN SC, may request that the mailing list/Discourse maintainer block the ability of the offending individual to post to the mailing list. (If the mailing list software permits this type of operation.) Even if this is done, the individual must not be prevented from receiving messages posted to the list. Other methods of mailing list control may be considered but must be approved by the responsible SC Member(s) and the BGIN SC.

3.3. Session management

BGIN consensus does not require that all participants agree although this is, of course, preferred. In general, the dominant view of the group shall prevail. (However, it must be noted that "dominance" is not to be determined on the basis of volume or persistence, but rather a more general sense of agreement.) Consensus can be determined by a show of hands or any other means on which the group agrees.

Unnecessary repeated discussions on issues can be avoided if the Group Chair makes sure that the main arguments in the discussion (and the outcome) are summarized and archived after a discussion has come to conclusion. It is also good practice to note important decisions/consensus reached by email in the minutes of the next ’live’ session, and to

summarize briefly the decision-making history in the final documents the Group produces. To facilitate making forward progress, a Group Chair may wish to decide to reject or defer the input from a member.

3.4. Contention and appeals

Disputes are possible at various stages during the BGIN process. As much as possible the process is designed so that compromises can be made, and genuine consensus achieved; however, there are times when even the most reasonable and knowledgeable people are unable to agree. To achieve the goals of openness and fairness, such conflicts must be resolved by a process of open review and discussion.

4. Group Termination

Groups are typically chartered to accomplish a specific task or tasks. After the tasks are complete, the group will be disbanded. If, at some point, it becomes evident that a group is unable to complete the work outlined in the charter, or if the assumptions which that work was based have been modified in discussion or by experience, the responsible SC Member, in consultation with the group can either: 1. Recharter to refocus its tasks, 2. Choose a new Chair(s), or 3. Disband. If the working group disagrees with the responsible SC Member's choice, it may appeal to the BGIN SC (see section 3.4).

5. Rechartering a Group

Updated milestones are renegotiated with the BGIN SC Member and the BGIN SC, as needed, and then are submitted to the Secretary General.

Rechartering (other than revising milestones) a group follows the same procedures that the initial chartering does (see section 2). The revised charter must be submitted to the BGIN SC for approval. As with the initial chartering, the BGIN may approve new charter as-is, it may request that changes be made in the new charter (including having the Working Group continue to use the old charter), or it may decline to approve the rechartered group. In the latter case, the group is disbanded.

6. Staff Role

6.1. Group Chair

The Group Chair is concerned with making forward progress through a fair and open process, and has wide discretion in the conduct of group business.

The Group Chair must ensure that a number of tasks are performed, either directly or by others assigned to the tasks. The Group Chair has the responsibility and the authority to make decisions, on behalf of the group, regarding all matters of group process and staffing, in conformance with the rules of the BGIN. The Responsible SC Member has the authority and the responsibility to assist in making those decisions at the request of the Chair or when circumstances warrant such an intervention.

The Group Chair's responsibility encompasses at least the following:

Ensure group process and content management

The Group Chair has ultimate responsibility for ensuring that a group achieves forward progress and meets its milestones. The Group Chair is also responsible to ensure that the group operates in an open and fair manner. For some groups, this can be accomplished by having the BGIN Chair perform all management-related activities. In other groups -- particularly those with large or divisive participation -- it is helpful to allocate process and/or secretarial functions to other participants. Process management pertains strictly to the style of group interaction and not to its content. It ensures fairness and detects redundancy. The secretarial function encompasses document editing. A group can assign the task of specification Editor to one or two participants. Sometimes, they also are part of the design team, described below.

Moderate the Group email list / Discourse

The Group Chair should attempt to ensure that the discussions on this list are relevant and that they converge to consensus agreements. The Chair should make sure that discussions on the list are summarized and that the outcome is well documented (to avoid repetition).

Plan Group Sessions

The Group Chair must plan and announce all WG sessions well in advance (see section 3.1).

Communicate results of sessions

The Group Chair and/or Secretary must ensure that minutes of a session are taken and that an attendance list is circulated via a mailing list / Discourse (see section 3.1).

Distribute the workload

Of course, each group will have participants who may not be able (or want) to do any work at all. Most of the time the bulk of the work is done by a few dedicated participants. It is the task of the Group Chair to motivate enough experts to allow for a fair distribution of the workload.

Document development

Working groups produce documents and documents need authors. The Group Chair must make sure that authors of Group documents incorporate changes as agreed to by the Group (see section 6.3).

Document publication

The Group Chair and/or Document Editor will ensure document conformance with publication requirements. A particular concern is that all participants are working from the same version of a document at the same time.

6.2. Group Secretary

Taking minutes and editing group documents often is performed by a specifically-designated participant or set of participants. In this role, the Secretary's job is to record Group decisions, rather than to perform basic specification. This role can be played by the Group Chairs or they can assign the role to participant(s).

6.3. Document Editor

Most groups focus their efforts on a document, or set of documents, that capture the results of the group's work. A group generally designates a person or persons to serve as the Editor for a particular document. The Document Editor is responsible for ensuring that the contents of the document accurately reflect the decisions that have been made by the group. As a general practice, the Group Chair and Document Editor positions are filled by different individuals to help ensure that the resulting documents accurately reflect the consensus of the working group and that all processes are followed.

6.4. Group Facilitator

When meetings tend to become distracted or divisive, it often is helpful to assign the task of "process management" to one participant. Their job is to oversee the nature, rather than the content, of participant interactions. That is, they attend to the style of the discussion and to the schedule of the agenda, rather than making direct contributions themselves.

6.5. Design teams

It is often useful, and perhaps inevitable, for a sub-group of a group to develop a proposal to solve a particular problem. Such a sub-group is called a design team. In order for a design team to remain small and agile, it is acceptable to have closed membership and private meetings. The output of a design team is always subject to approval, rejection or modification by the Group as a whole.

6.6. Responsible SC Member

The responsible SC Members are responsible for ensuring that groups in their area produce output as a contribution to the overall results of the BGIN.

7. Documents

7.1. Session documents

All relevant documents to be discussed at a session should be published and available at least one week before a session starts. Any document which does not meet this publication deadline can only be discussed in a group session with the specific approval of the group chair(s). Since it is important that group members have adequate time to review all documents, granting such an exception should only be done under unusual conditions. The final session agenda should be posted to the group mailing list at least one week before the session and sent at that time.

7.2. Agreed documents

Agreed documents refers to those proposing content deemed suitable to suggest as the standard in the industry. Such documents, which apply to Proposed, Draft, and Standard, are submitted to the BGIN SC by the responsible SC Member after their coordination with Group Chairs.

All agreed documents must be formatted according to the method decided by BGIN, and they must be numbered. Group Chairs must ensure that this work is carried out thoroughly.

After approval by BGIN SC, the Group Secretary (or Secretary General as necessary) will publish the document on the mailing list, discourse, and website, under the direction of Group Chairs.

7.3. Study reports

Study reports refer to those aiming to provide a comprehensive and in-depth analysis of a specific topic or research area, often based on data collection, literature review, and case studies. Such documents, which apply to Draft and Final, are submitted to the BGIN SC by the responsible SC Member after their coordination with Group Chairs.

All study reports must be formatted according to the method decided by BGIN, and they must be numbered. Group Chairs must ensure that this work is carried out thoroughly.

After approval by BGIN SC, the Group Secretary (or Secretary General as necessary) will publish the document on the mailing list, discourse, and website, under the direction of Group Chairs.

7.4. Discussion papers

Discussion papers refer to those designed to stimulate dialogue and discussion among different stakeholders which outlines challenges, potential solutions, and key questions rather than delivering definitive conclusions.

If the document is referred to a WG/SG, the WG/SG can recommend that the document be adopted as a WG document and that it be published. The responsible SC Member for the WG is responsible for getting a response from the WG in a timely manner.

All study reports must be formatted according to the method decided by BGIN, and they must be numbered. Group Chairs must ensure that this work is carried out thoroughly.

The Group Secretary (or Secretary General as necessary) will publish the document on the mailing list, discourse, and website, under the direction of Group Chairs.

8. Review of documents

The BGIN SC review procedures are defined by the BGIN SC, which are described in the Steering Committee Charter 5.2 and the Process Document 4.3.

9. Acknowledgements

This document relies heavily on the contributions by Steering Committee Members and the Secretary Office as of November 2024.

10. References

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